REWRITING THE LUST STORY

THE NARRATIVE AROUND SEX, PLEASURE AND SEXUAL WELLNESS HAS BEEN HYPER-MASCULINE AND MISOGYNISTIC FOR TOO LONG. IT IS TIME FOR WOMEN TO CLAIM THAT SPACE

By **SACHEE MALHOTRA**

Is **INDIA READY FOR A SEX-POSITIVE REVOLUTION?** Instagram says so. With so many educators and influencers bringing sex-positive conversations to the forefront, you'll soon see a world where people are openly discussing body positivity, sexual health and pleasure. It is indeed encouraging for entrepreneurs like me who are in the business of changing mindsets. Having said that, what's on the gram isn't always the whole truth. When I look around, I see generations of people raised with little to absolutely no Sex Ed at all, weighed down by misogyny and patriarchal norms. People may claim to know about sex, but most of them have been coached by mainstream porn because, sadly, our school SOPs were particular about skipping any chapters related to our anatomy or the basics of sex education.

Internalised misogyny

When young girls are conditioned to look and behave a certain way, how can we expect them to have agency over their bodies when they grow up? I remember my own childhood when I was told to wear clothes that wouldn't make me look 'fat' or makeup that wasn't 'too much'. I remember giving up on so many of those cute frocks as a little girl just because I was told I have 'thunder thighs'. The question is, who decides what looks good on that girl? Shouldn't every girl be empowered to decide for herself? For some, it may be just a small anecdote, but this shame and lack of confidence in your body at such a young age has a lasting impact on so many women as they grow up.

We're fighting this today by showing diverse bodies—big, small, thick, thin, all shapes and sizes, in our communication. We show women with body hair, stretch marks, dimples, pimples—raw and real. In doing so, we're normalising all types of bodies and helping people feel more affirmed in theirs. We also work with credible educators and content creators to bust myths around the 'perfect body'.

Women ignored in the sexual wellness space

The sexual wellness market has been drowning in the sea of sameness—crowded with brands owned by men, making products that cater primarily to the needs of men and, in the process, serving the male gaze. When the narrative around sex and pleasure has been so utterly hyper-masculine and misogynistic for long, it becomes challenging for women to find that one voice in a space so cramped that understands them, relates to them and empowers them.

When there aren't enough conversations about a vulva owner's pleasure, the power dynamics automatically skew towards men in the bedroom. This is one of the main reasons behind the orgasm gap (in a cis-het relationship). Speaking of a personal instance, I had a close friend who I knew was getting treated for vaginismus, but her partner often claimed, "I prefer natural lubrication. Lubes and condoms are so overrated." She'd been having painful sex for years without addressing the issue or being able to talk about it with her partner.